Only Kidding!

By Jim Geoghan

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *The old-school world of stand-up saw its fair share of successful comedy duos.*
ACTOR 2: *The formula sounds simple: one comic plays the straight man, setting up big laughs for the other.*
ACTOR 1: *But a winning comedy duo requires great chemistry, exceptional writing, and even the ability to adlib.*
ACTOR 2: *Meet Tom and Jerry*
ACTOR 1: *(No pun intended)*
ACTOR 2: *an aspiring young comedy team – eager to "make it big" in the world - but also struggling to find themselves.*
ACTOR 1: *The pressure to always be "on" can get to the best of us –*
ACTOR 2: *And when comedy becomes bitter, it's more than . . . .*
TOGETHER: *Only Kidding! By Jim Goeghan.*

TOM: Good show.

JERRY: Good? It was terrific!

TOM: You see the guy in the front row? How hard he laughed?

JERRY: The Fat guy?

TOM: Yeah, him.

JERRY: The bartender loved the show, too. Watched every bit we did.

TOM: He had such a good time he forgot to steal from the cash register. You messed up though.

JERRY: What do you mean I messed up

TOM: You dropped some lines. A whole section.

JERRY: Hey, we're a team, remember? We don't mess up individually. If something goes wrong, it's because of us. Together.

TOM: Okay, so "we" messed up tonight.

JERRY: That's it.

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TOM: Because you dropped some lines.

JERRY: Cute. *(In a very effeminate voice)* Yes, this is Jerry Goldstein.

TOM: What are you doing?

JERRY: Calling my answering service. You talk like [this], they don't put you on hold. Hmmm? She did? When did that come in? *(PAUSE)* Oh, Fabulous! Ciao.

TOM: Jerry, do you realize we haven't done a new bit in over eight months?

JERRY: Bull. We do new stuff all the time.

TOM: Bits and pieces. A line here, a line there. Hunks. Hunks. I want to do new hunks.

JERRY: Why's it so important?

TOM: Because I am bored to death with our old stuff. I'm daydreaming on stage. . . Did you say you got another commercial?

JERRY: Yeah. Yippie Dog Food. It's a national, too. I film it next week. Guess who the director is?

TOM: No idea.

JERRY: Sam Peckinpaw. Get it? Paw . . . Peckin-paw.

TOM: I got it.

JERRY: This dog won't eat the dog food. . . . So I shoot 'im.

TOM: Kids oughta love it.

JERRY: It's great. It's in slow motion and everything. C'mon, man. Lighten up. We did a good show tonight. Now it's time to cruise the bar for chicks. Bring them down here into our deluxe dressing room.

TOM: Yeah, sure. Don't start that again.

JERRY: Hey, you never know, man, you never know.

TOM: Jerry, how long have you been a comedian?

JERRY: As long as we've been together. Five years.

TOM: And in those five years, how many times have you gotten a girl as a direct result of your being a comedian?

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JERRY: As a direct result?

TOM: Direct, indirect, whatever.

JERRY: (Thinks) Approximately . . . . none.

TOM: I keep telling you that we're comedians . . . rock stars get all the girls! *(They look at each other for a beat, then break into an improvisational jazz riff – Tom playing bass, Jerry guitar. When they are done they laugh)*

JERRY: Still there's hope that out there in this world there's a young and beautiful girl with a very low IQ and equally low self-esteem . . . looking to get back at her parents in her own peculiar way . . .

TOM: That's a beautiful dream, Jer.

JERRY: I know. I'm a hopeless romantic

TOM: You're crazy, man! You know that?!

JERRY: Think I'll stay up all night tonight

TOM: Like you've got a choice.

JERRY: Couldn't sleep if I wanted to. I've got a nine a.m. audition tomorrow. I'm gonna nail that one too. You just watch.

TOM: Why do you bother with that Jerry?

JERRY: Why? For the money, that's why. It's going to help overcome the three things I've go going against me. I'm poor, ugly and Jewish.

TOM: You make it sound like it's some sort of disease or something. Like . . . *(as a solemn doctor)*. I'm sorry, sir. Your test results are I and I'm afraid you are suffering from Poor, ugly, Jewish.

JERRY: *(As an old Jewish man)* Ach! Doctor, is there any cure?

TOM: Money . . . big piles of money.

JERRY: Ach! Never say big piles to an old Jew!

TOM: Sir, about my bill. If you're poor, how are you going to pay me?

JERRY: Oh, great! Now my hearing's shot, too!

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TOM: My bill, sir.

JERRY: Can't hear a thing.

TOM: You owe me . . .

JERRY: Deaf like a stone. Hello?

TOM: Hello.

JERRY: Hello

(Tom segues his Hello into an impression Jerry Lewis emceeing a telethon)

TOM: Hello! And welcome to the seventeenth hour of our telethon coming to you from our studio of love in Los Angeles.

JERRY: It's lovely here. We come every year.

TOM: With us now is this year's poster child for poor, ugly, Jewish . . . Mister Jerry Goldstein.

JERRY: Hello!

TOM: Jerry is ugly.

JERRY: It hasn't been a good year.

TOM: Boy, is he ugly. . . Real ugly.

JERRY: All right, already.

TOM: He's so ugly the mice walk hunchback.

JERRY: Enough with the ugly!

TOM: But someday with the help . . .

JERRY: Thank you, McDonalds Corporation!

TOM: Jerry will be rich, handsome and Gentile.

JERRY: Think so?

TOM: It could happen.

JERRY: It would take a miracle.

TOM: *(Singing)* Walk on, walk on with hope in your heart and you'll never walk alone! You'll never walk alone!

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(A strange force seems to take Jerry over. His Yiddish accent disappears, he rises to his feet and feels his body tingle as Tom sings)

JERRY: What's going on? I feel the power . . . Oh, my God! I'm breaking out in argyle!! Quick! Someone get me a pipe! (As Ward Cleaver) June! Wally! Beaver! I'm home. Come on. Let's hop in the Volvo and drive back to Connecticut. These kids! Where do they get the energy? Meanwhile, we'll try and figure out what I do for a living. Oh, what the heck. Let's buy retail! *(Tom and Jerry laugh from the fun they've had and Tom jots down some notes as Jerry watches)* Volvo . . . Hop in the Volvo . . .

TOM: I got it . . I got it. Remember when you were a kid . . . the way you would insult each other's mother? Like your mother's so low she could play handball against a curb.

JERRY: Right, right, or your mother wears combat boots.

TOM: Or, uh . . Your mother eats . . . Dirt!

JERRY: Oh, oh! I got it, two kids in England and insulting each other's mother. O.K.? Two kids in England, I say!

TOM: Yes?

JERRY:: Your mother is . . . . . inappropriate.

TOM: How dare you. You take that back.

JERRY: I shan't.

TOM: You shan't?? You shan't because your mother . . .

JERRY: Yes?

TOM: Your mother is . . . Ostentatious.

JERRY: You despicable lout!

TOM: Watch your mouth, dear boy.

JERRY: You're dashing for a thrashing.

TOM: I shall be forced to give you the finger.

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JERRY: You leave no choice but to respond in the like kind.

TOM: Very well . . . the finger.

JERRY: The finger.

(Back to original characters).

JERRY: You know what? We're too damn good for toilets like this. Look at this dump, and we're working for chump change. . . . I've been thinking. We ought to sign that contract. With Sal as our agent. He says he can get us on Letterman.

TOM: Signing a management contract with Sal could be the worst mistake of our entire lives.

JERRY: Tom, Sal's got us our shot. All we have to so is sign.

TOM: All we have to do is NOT sign . . . keep doing good shows, get better and better as an act. We'll get on the Letterman show without getting involved with Sal. It's not worth it, Jerry. This contract's for seven years. Seven years, Jerry.

JERRY: Seven's my luck number!

TOM: Sal wants thirty percent before an agent takes his ten. He wants to put in lounges . . . Lounges! Opening for guys who sing "feelings" and play the accordion.

JERRY: You don't know the way my gut aches to get on Letterman. Another young comedian, and another young comedian . . . but never us! Me! Twenty million people! The ones who tormented and teased and humiliated me . . . the ones who stole my lunch money . . . the creeps who called me Jewboy! I want to do it . . Now!

TOM: The price is too high.

JERRY: I want you to sign this and I want you to sign this right now.

TOM: Who are you? Have we met? You look a lot like my partner . . . No way!

JERRY: Your last chance. Sign it or else.

TOM: Is being pathetic an Olympic sport yet? If it is, you should try out for the team.

JERRY: Get out.

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TOM: What?

JERRY: I said get out of here! Get out of my dressing room!

TOM: You're crazy.

JERRY: We're through. I'm sick and tired of you holding me back. We're through! Get out of here.

TOM: What are you doing? Stop!

JERRY: Do this to me? Do a thing like this to me?!! Who do you think you are? You are no one! I hate your fricking guts!!! *(Tom slaps Jerry hard across the face and it stops Jerry cold)*

TOM: What are you, crazy? Who sat up with you in Atlanta when you thought you were going to die? Who? Remember a hundred and five fever? Who stayed up with you for two days and nights? Was it David Letterman? Was it Sal? Who was it?! Are you in there? Are you in there somewhere? *(Tom waits for a reply. There is none. After several beats, he let's go of Jerry. Jerry gathers himself.)*

JERRY: I'm going to send you a color TV, Kelly. A great big one. You can watch me kill on Letterman. Alone. Without you.

TOM: Yeah, sure . . . You do that. Looks like you've got everything you need. *(Tom surveys Jerry for a few beats, then sadly exits.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jim Geoghan
ISBN: 978-0573691942
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): 1990

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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